Investment Scam Protection Checklist

A verification and incident-response system for impersonation, false platforms, recovery scams and high-pressure offers.

MATRIX REPROGRAMMED - DETAILED WEALTH GUIDE

Reader outcome: Verify authorisation, identity, custody, documents and payment instructions before money moves.

Best for: Any investor, saver or family member approached with an investment, trading, crypto, property or recovery offer.

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Educational information only. No personalised financial, investment, legal or tax advice. No guaranteed outcomes.

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1. Fraud works through urgency and trust

Scammers create authority, scarcity, secrecy, social proof or fear of missing out.
Professional design, a copied registration number or a familiar name does not prove identity.
Victims can include experienced people because fraud targets normal decision shortcuts.
Slow the process and verify through independent channels before discussing payment.

2. Independent identity verification

Find the legal entity name in the offer and compare it with official registers.
Use contact details obtained independently from the regulator or established official site.
Check domain spelling, registration history, email suffix and physical address.
Call the authorised firm through its official switchboard to confirm the individual and offer.
Beware of clone firms using a real company name with different contact details.

3. Authorisation and product permission

Confirm the firm is authorised for the specific service and jurisdiction.
Check warnings and blacklists, but absence from a blacklist is not proof of safety.
Crowdfunding, insurance, credit, investment advice and crypto services may use different registers.
Ask the regulator when the status is unclear rather than accepting the promoter explanation.

4. Custody and payment

Identify the regulated custodian, account owner and legal treatment of client assets.
Never pay to a personal account, unrelated company, crypto wallet or newly changed bank instruction without independent confirmation.
Confirm withdrawal rights, transfer restrictions and insolvency treatment.
Test the payment route with the bank fraud team when concern exists.

5. Return and risk claims

Guaranteed high return, low risk and immediate liquidity rarely coexist.
Ask for the precise source of return and who bears loss.
Reject screenshots, testimonials and account dashboards as independent evidence.
Check whether returns depend mainly on recruiting new participants or continuously rising prices.
Do not borrow, release home equity or use essential money because the offer is time-limited.

6. Document review

Read issuer, product, fee, risk, cancellation, custody and complaint documents.
Check names, registration numbers, addresses and bank details across documents.
Look for copied text, inconsistent jurisdiction, missing audited accounts and impossible claims.
Have complex contracts reviewed before payment, not after a dispute.

7. Crypto and trading-platform risks

A visible balance may be a fake interface with no underlying asset.
Small early withdrawals can be allowed to build trust before larger deposits are blocked.
Requests for tax, insurance or unlocking payments before withdrawal are major red flags.
Remote-access software can expose banking and identity information.
Leverage, derivatives and unregulated offshore platforms can create legitimate losses as well as fraud risk.

8. Recovery scams

Victims are frequently targeted again by supposed lawyers, regulators, investigators or asset-recovery firms.
No legitimate recovery is guaranteed.
Verify identity and authority independently.
Be extremely cautious with upfront fees, secrecy, crypto payment or claims of hacked funds.
Share evidence only through secure official channels.

9. If money has been sent

Contact the bank or payment provider immediately and request the fraud process.
Preserve emails, messages, phone numbers, domains, wallet addresses, receipts and account details.
Change compromised passwords and secure email and phone accounts.
Report through the relevant police, regulator and platform routes.
Do not continue paying to unlock or recover funds.
Seek emotional and practical support; shame delays action and benefits the fraudster.

10. Pre-payment checklist

[ ] Legal entity verified independently.
[ ] Specific authorisation verified.
[ ] Official contact confirmed the offer.
[ ] Custody and client-money treatment understood.
[ ] Bank account owner matches the verified entity.
[ ] Risk and fee documents read.

10. Pre-payment checklist (continued)

[ ] Return mechanism explained without guarantees.

[ ] Withdrawal process tested or documented.

[ ] No urgency, secrecy or remote access.

[ ] A trusted independent person reviewed the evidence.

11. How to use this guide

Purpose: Verify authorisation, identity, custody, documents and payment instructions before money moves.
Best reader: Any investor, saver or family member approached with an investment, trading, crypto, property or recovery offer.
Read the guide once without taking action. On the second pass, complete the checklists and write down the evidence supporting each decision.
Replace every example number with your own verified amount, date, fee, tax treatment, contract term or source document.
Do not treat a checklist tick as proof. Keep copies of the underlying statements, quotations, filings, contracts and calculations.
For major decisions, use this guide to prepare better questions for a regulated adviser, accountant, lawyer, lender or insurer.

12. Evidence standard

Tier 1: law, regulator, tax authority, court, audited accounts, official product document or signed contract.
Tier 2: recognised institutional research that states its methodology, date and limitations.
Tier 3: reputable reporting used to identify questions, not to replace primary evidence.
Tier 4: marketing, social posts, testimonials, screenshots and anonymous claims. Treat these as unverified leads.
Write the source date beside every changing figure. A correct figure without a date can become misleading.
Separate facts, estimates, assumptions and scenarios. Never allow a scenario to be presented as a forecast or guarantee.
A company, fund, adviser, trust, structure, transaction or association is not proof of misconduct.

13. Decision record worksheet

[ ] State the decision in one sentence.

[ ] State the desired result and deadline.

[ ] List the three strongest pieces of supporting evidence.

[ ] List the three strongest reasons the decision may fail.

[ ] Record the maximum acceptable loss of money, time and flexibility.

[ ] Record the smallest reversible test.

13. Decision record worksheet (continued)

[ ] Name the person responsible for checking legal, tax or regulatory consequences.
[ ] Set the next review date and the evidence that would cause you to stop.

14. Professional advice triggers

Seek regulated investment advice when product suitability, risk capacity, pensions, insurance or a large portfolio decision is unclear.
Seek tax advice before changing residence, extracting company cash, transferring assets, using trusts, gifting substantial sums or entering cross-border arrangements.
Seek legal advice before signing guarantees, shareholder agreements, acquisition contracts, complex leases, loan security or beneficiary arrangements.
Seek accounting advice when turnover, VAT, payroll, inventory, multiple activities or company-group transactions become material.
Use a defined written question. Paying for broad reassurance without documents or calculations rarely produces a useful answer.

15. Subject focus map

Use the following subject anchors as named checkpoints. For each checkpoint, record the fact, source, date, assumption, decision and next review date.
INDEPENDENT VERIFICATION: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
AUTHORISATION: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
CUSTODY: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
RECOVERY SCAM: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
Do not mark a checkpoint complete because an action was taken. Mark it complete only when the result and supporting evidence have been recorded.
Where a checkpoint depends on another person, institution, platform or contract, record that dependency and a fallback route.
Rank checkpoints by potential harm if ignored, not by how interesting or easy they appear.
At the end of each review, choose one checkpoint to advance and one risk to reduce before adding a new objective.

16. Worked decision case

Write a real decision from your own situation at the top of a blank page. Examples include changing work, launching an offer, choosing an account, buying an asset, restructuring a business or rejecting a proposal.
Baseline: state the current cash, income, liabilities, commitments, ownership, legal position and time available. Use documents rather than memory where possible.

16. Worked decision case (continued)

Desired result: describe the measurable outcome, deadline and reason. Remove vague language such as more, better, passive, safe or guaranteed.
Options: include the proposed action, a smaller reversible test, a diversified alternative, delaying the action and doing nothing.
Evidence: attach at least three independent sources. Identify which evidence is official, contractual, audited, estimated, promotional or missing.
Economics: show setup cost, recurring cost, cash timing, fees, tax reserve, downside loss, opportunity cost and the point at which the decision becomes worthwhile.
Risk: identify concentration, liquidity, legal, operational, fraud, health, relationship and behavioural risks. Name the risk that could create irreversible harm.
Professional review: write the exact question that requires an accountant, lawyer, regulated adviser, lender, insurer or technical specialist.
Decision: state proceed, test, delay or reject. Record the maximum commitment and the evidence required before any further commitment.
Review: set a dated checkpoint. Write the result that would confirm the decision, the result that would require adjustment and the result that would trigger an immediate stop.

17. 90-day implementation workbook

Week 1 - Establish the baseline. Reconcile the relevant accounts, contracts, statements, fees, tax records, responsibilities and deadlines.
Week 2 - Define the result. Choose one measurable outcome and remove actions that do not directly support it or protect an essential risk.
Week 3 - Gather primary evidence. Use official registers, filings, signed terms, current quotations and dated institutional data.
Week 4 - Compare alternatives. Include a lower-cost option, a lower-risk option, a reversible test and the option to wait.
Week 5 - Model the economics. Build downside, base and upside cases while treating every uncertain input as an assumption.
Week 6 - Verify identity and authority. Confirm who owns, controls, advises, holds money, signs contracts and bears liability.
Week 7 - Run the smallest useful test. Limit money, time and legal commitment while collecting evidence about real demand or performance.
Week 8 - Reconcile actual results. Compare promised, expected and actual cost, time, cash flow, quality, risk and customer or counterparty behaviour.
Week 9 - Repair the constraint. Improve the single factor currently limiting income, retention, safety, liquidity, delivery or evidence quality.
Week 10 - Install controls. Add calendar reminders, approval limits, account separation, written procedures, backups and review ownership.
Week 11 - Decide whether to scale. Increase commitment only when the test produced measurable value and the downside remains affordable.
Week 12 - Complete the evidence file. Store the decision record, sources,

17. 90-day implementation workbook (continued)

calculations, contracts, results, lessons and next review date.
Day 90 - Write a one-page conclusion: what was established, what remains uncertain, what changed, what will continue and what will stop.

18. Review, escalation and stop rules

Review monthly when the decision affects recurring cash, debt, customer commitments, investment contributions or essential protection.
Review immediately after a material legal change, tax notice, contract change, security incident, missed payment, large loss, health event or relationship change.
Escalate to a qualified professional when the facts cross jurisdictions, involve regulated products, create personal guarantees, affect beneficiaries or cannot be reversed cheaply.
Pause when required documents are missing, identities cannot be independently verified, costs are unclear or the counterparty resists reasonable due diligence.
Stop when the action requires deception, undeclared income, false invoices, hidden beneficial ownership, unaffordable leverage or essential-living money.
Stop when actual cash use, delivery time or loss exceeds the written limit.
Stop when the central evidence is corrected, withdrawn, contradicted by a stronger source or no longer current.
Do not move a stop limit merely because money, pride or time has already been committed. Sunk cost is not evidence that continuing is rational.
Record every exception to the plan, who approved it and why. Repeated exceptions indicate the plan or control is not working.
A stopped action can still be a successful decision when it prevents a larger loss and preserves the ability to act later.

19. Evidence and legal boundary

This is educational information, not personalised financial, investment, legal, accounting or tax advice.
Investments can fall in value. Businesses can fail. Debt, leverage, illiquidity, tax and legal obligations can create losses greater than the expected benefit.
Rules and thresholds change. Verify the current official position on the date of action.
Never use false invoices, hidden ownership, undeclared income, sham transactions, misleading applications or borrowed essential-living money.
No return, saving, valuation, tax outcome or business result is guaranteed.

20. Official research routes

1. AMF - Verify an authorisation - https://www.amf-france.org/fr/espace-epargnants/proteger-son-epargne/faire-les-verifications
2. AMF - Blacklists and warnings -

20. Official research routes (continued)

https://www.amf-france.org/fr/espace-epargnants/proteger-son-epargne/listes-noires-et-mises-en-garde

3. REGAFI - Regulated financial firms register - https://www.regafi.fr/
4. ORIAS - Intermediary register - https://www.orias.fr/
5. ESMA investor information - https://www.esma.europa.eu/investor-corner